

Core Management Skills for Teachers

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Core Management Skills for Teachers

Harry Wong and Rosemary Wong (2009) point out that the biggest problem in most classrooms is not bad behavior. The real problem is that the class has no clear procedures and routines. In simple words, a teacher must know the subject, but the teacher must also know how to manage.

1. INTRODUCTION

A teacher does many jobs in a single day. The teacher plans lessons, keeps the class in order, checks copies, talks to parents, fills registers and works with other staff members. Each of these jobs needs management.

Many people think management is only the job of the principal. This is not true. Every teacher is the manager of his or her own classroom. A classroom has people (students), time (periods), things (books, board, charts) and a goal (learning). The teacher has to use all of these in the right way. The abilities that help a teacher do this are called management skills.

This assignment explains the meaning of management skills, why teachers need them, the theories behind them, the core skills a teacher should have, the problems teachers face, and the ways teachers can improve these skills.

2. MEANING OF MANAGEMENT AND MANAGEMENT SKILLS

Management means getting work done in an organized way by making good use of people, time and resources. Henri Fayol (1949) explained that management has five main functions: planning, organizing, commanding, coordinating and controlling.

A skill is an ability that we learn and improve with practice. So management skills are the abilities that help a person plan, organize, guide and check work.

For a teacher, management skills are the abilities that help him or her run the classroom smoothly, use time and material wisely, guide students and reach the learning goals. Nobody is born with these skills. A teacher learns them through training, practice and experience.

3. IMPORTANCE OF MANAGEMENT SKILLS FOR TEACHERS

Management skills are important for teachers because:

- They save time, so more time is left for actual teaching.

- They keep discipline in the class without shouting or punishment.
- They make students feel safe, and safe students learn better.
- They help the teacher complete the syllabus on time.
- They build good relations with students, parents and colleagues.
- They reduce the teacher's own stress and tiredness.
- They help the whole school run smoothly.

4. THEORIES RELATED TO MANAGEMENT SKILLS

A few well-known theories help us understand which skills a teacher needs and why.

Katz's Three Skills Model (1955)

Robert Katz said that every manager needs three kinds of skills. Technical skills mean knowing how to do the job, such as knowing the subject and the methods of teaching. Human skills mean working well with people. Conceptual skills mean seeing the whole picture and understanding how the parts are linked. A teacher needs all three. Katz said human skills are needed at every level, and this is especially true for teachers because they deal with people all day.

Fayol's Functions of Management (1949)

Fayol's five functions also fit the classroom. The teacher plans the lesson, organizes the class and material, gives directions to students (commanding), links different activities together (coordinating), and checks whether students have learned (controlling).

Kounin's Classroom Management Theory (1970)

Jacob Kounin observed many classrooms and found that good teachers stop problems before they start. He called this “withitness”, which means the teacher knows what is going on in every corner of the room. He also talked about “overlapping”, which means dealing with two things at once, and about moving smoothly from one activity to the next without breaks.

McGregor's Theory X and Theory Y (1960)

Douglas McGregor said that managers see people in two ways. Theory X says people are lazy and need strict control. Theory Y says people like to work and will take responsibility if they are trusted. A teacher who believes in Theory Y gives students some responsibility, for example as class monitors or group leaders, and this builds their confidence.

Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs (1943)

Abraham Maslow said that human needs come in steps: body needs (food, rest), safety, love and belonging, respect, and finally self-actualization, which means becoming the best person one can be. A child who is hungry, scared or ignored cannot learn well. So a good teacher first makes students feel safe and respected, and then learning becomes easier.

5. CORE MANAGEMENT SKILLS FOR TEACHERS

The main management skills that every teacher needs are explained below with simple school examples.

5.1 Planning Skill

Planning means deciding in advance what to do, how to do it and when to do it. A teacher makes a yearly scheme of work, monthly targets and daily lesson plans. A good lesson plan has clear objectives, teaching aids, activities and a way to check learning. Without planning, time is wasted and the syllabus is left incomplete before the exams. For example, a teacher who divides the syllabus into weekly parts at the start of the term can finish it on time and still have time for revision.

5.2 Organizing Skill

Organizing means arranging people and things so that the plan can work. The teacher sets the seating plan, keeps teaching aids ready, makes groups, and gives duties to students such as monitor, board cleaner or copy collector. Resources like charts, books and science kits are also kept in a fixed place. In a well-organized class, no time is wasted in looking for chalk, markers or notebooks.

5.3 Classroom Management and Discipline Skill

This is the most basic skill of a teacher. It means keeping the class calm, orderly and ready to learn. On the first day, the teacher makes a few clear rules and then follows them every day. Good teachers use eye contact, walk around the room and speak in a calm but firm voice instead of shouting or hitting. They praise good behavior more often than they punish bad behavior. A teacher with Kounin's "withitness" notices small problems early, such as two students whispering at the back, and handles them before they grow.

5.4 Time Management Skill

A period is usually only 35 to 40 minutes long, so every minute counts. Time management means using class time and personal time in the best way. The teacher starts the class on time, takes attendance quickly, and divides the period into parts, for example 5 minutes for review, 20 minutes for teaching, 10 minutes for practice and 5 minutes for homework. Copies can be checked on fixed days. Covey (1989) advised that we should put important tasks first and not let small urgent tasks eat up all our time.

5.5 Communication Skill

Communication means sharing ideas and information clearly. Every day a teacher talks to students, parents, colleagues and the head teacher. Good communication needs simple words, a clear voice, suitable body language and careful listening. It should be two-way, so the teacher asks questions and also lets students speak. In a parent-teacher meeting, a teacher who explains a child's weakness politely and with examples gets much more support from the parents.

5.6 Leadership Skill

In the classroom, the teacher is the leader. Leadership means guiding and inspiring others toward a goal. A good teacher leads by example. If the teacher comes on time, dresses neatly, speaks politely and keeps promises, students learn to do the same, because they copy what they see more than what they hear. The teacher can also share leadership by making students group leaders, which teaches them responsibility, just as McGregor's Theory Y suggests.

5.7 Decision-Making and Problem-Solving Skill

A teacher has to make many small and big decisions every day. Which method should be used today? What should be done with a student who keeps forgetting homework? How can a weak student be helped? Simon (1960) explained that decision making has three steps: finding the problem, finding the possible choices, and selecting the best one. A good teacher never decides in anger. The teacher first collects the facts, thinks about the options and then takes a fair decision.

5.8 Human Relations and Teamwork Skill

A teacher does not work alone. The teacher works with other teachers, the head teacher, support staff and parents. Human relations skill means getting along with people, respecting them and working as a team. Teachers of the same class can share lesson ideas, prepare tests

together and help each other with duties such as exam invigilation. Katz (1955) called this the “human skill” and said it is needed at every level of management.

5.9 Motivation Skill

Motivation means creating a wish to learn in students. A motivated student learns faster and behaves better. The teacher can motivate students by praising effort, giving small rewards like stars or a “student of the week” title, linking lessons to real life and using interesting activities and games. As Maslow (1943) showed, the teacher should also make students feel safe, accepted and respected, because these needs come before learning.

5.10 Conflict Management Skill

Conflicts happen in every school, between students, between teachers, or between a teacher and a parent. Conflict management means solving these disagreements in a calm and fair way. Thomas and Kilmann (1974) described five ways of handling conflict: competing, avoiding, accommodating (giving in), compromising, and collaborating (working together to find a solution that suits both sides). In schools, collaborating usually works best. For example, when two students quarrel over a seat, the teacher listens to both of them and helps them agree on a fair rule.

5.11 Record Keeping and Evaluation Skill

A teacher has to keep many records, such as the attendance register, result sheets, progress reports and the lesson diary. Evaluation means checking how much students have learned through tests, class work, homework and oral questions. Good records show the teacher which students need extra help, and they are also needed in meetings with parents and the head teacher. Records should be complete, correct, neat and up to date.

5.12 Self-Management and Stress Control Skill

A teacher cannot manage others well without first managing himself or herself. Self-management means controlling one's own feelings, time and health. Teaching can be tiring because of large classes, heavy checking work and extra duties. A teacher who stays calm, takes short breaks, plans the week ahead and keeps a positive attitude handles pressure better and does not take out anger on students.

Table 1 below gives a short summary of these skills.

Table 1: Summary of Core Management Skills for Teachers

Skill	Simple Meaning	Classroom Example
Planning	Deciding in advance what, how and when	Dividing the syllabus into weekly parts
Organizing	Arranging people and things	Seating plan, groups, class monitors
Classroom Management	Keeping the class calm and ready to learn	Clear rules made on the first day
Time Management	Using every minute well	Dividing the period into fixed parts
Communication	Sharing ideas clearly, both ways	Polite talk in a parent-teacher meeting
Leadership	Guiding others by example	Coming on time, making group leaders
Decision-Making	Choosing the best option fairly	Deciding about missing homework
Human Relations	Working well with others	Preparing tests with colleagues
Motivation	Creating a wish to learn	Praise, stars, student of the week
Conflict Management	Solving disagreements fairly	Two students quarreling over a seat
Record Keeping	Keeping records and checking learning	Attendance register, result sheet
Self-Management	Controlling own feelings, time, health	Staying calm under pressure

6. PROBLEMS TEACHERS FACE IN USING MANAGEMENT SKILLS

Even when teachers know these skills, using them is not always easy. Some common problems in our schools are:

- Large classes, sometimes with 60 or more students in one room
- Lack of teaching aids, furniture, labs and other resources
- Extra non-teaching duties such as surveys, campaigns and election duty
- Little training in management during teacher education and on the job
- Heavy syllabus and pressure to show good exam results
- Students from different backgrounds, languages and learning levels

- Low salary and low motivation in some schools
- Weak support from parents in some areas

7. HOW TEACHERS CAN IMPROVE THEIR MANAGEMENT SKILLS

7.1 Training and Workshops

Teachers should attend in-service training, workshops and refresher courses on classroom management, lesson planning and communication. Short online courses can also help teachers learn at their own pace.

7.2 Learning from Senior Teachers

New teachers can observe the classes of experienced teachers and ask them for advice. A senior teacher can act as a mentor and guide a new teacher in handling difficult students and parents.

7.3 Reflection and Self-Evaluation

After each class, the teacher can ask three questions: What went well? What went wrong? What will I change tomorrow? Writing the answers in a small teaching diary helps the teacher notice patterns and improve step by step.

7.4 Setting Clear Rules and Routines

Fixed routines for entering the class, taking out books, submitting copies and leaving the room save a lot of time. Wong and Wong (2009) explain that routines taught in the first days of school make the whole year easier for both the teacher and the students.

7.5 Using Simple Tools and Technology

A daily planner, a timetable on the wall, a seating chart and a simple marks register help the teacher stay organized. Mobile reminders, digital calendars and class WhatsApp groups for parents can also save time when they are used carefully.

7.6 Support from the Head Teacher

The head teacher should give teachers a fair workload, the resources they need and the freedom to try new methods. Appreciating good work in staff meetings also builds the confidence of teachers.

7.7 Caring for One's Own Health

Teachers should take enough rest, eat well and keep a balance between school work and home life. A healthy and fresh teacher manages the class much better than a tired one.

Table 2 links some common classroom problems with the skill that helps to solve them.

Table 2: Classroom Problems and the Skills that Solve Them

Problem	Skill Needed	Simple Solution
Noisy class	Classroom management	Clear rules, eye contact, moving around
Syllabus not complete	Planning and time management	Weekly targets, fixed plan for each period
Students not interested	Motivation	Praise, activities, real-life examples
Parents not cooperating	Communication	Polite meetings and regular updates
Fights among students	Conflict management	Listen to both sides, agree on a fair rule
Too much paperwork	Record keeping	Update registers daily, use simple formats
Very large class	Organizing	Small groups with group leaders
Teacher feeling stressed	Self-management	Rest, weekly planning, positive attitude

8. CONCLUSION

A teacher is not just someone who delivers lessons. A teacher is the manager of a small world called the classroom. Skills such as planning, organizing, classroom management, time management, communication, leadership, decision making, teamwork, motivation, conflict management, record keeping and self-management help the teacher do this job well. The ideas of Fayol, Katz, Kounin, McGregor and Maslow show that good management is about caring for people as much as it is about finishing work.

These skills are not a gift that only some people are born with. Every teacher can learn them through training, practice and honest reflection. When teachers manage well, students feel safe, time is used properly, results improve, and the whole school becomes a better place to learn.

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